

The Prophet -The Role Model: Respect of Others

إن الحمد لله نحمده ونستعينه ونستغفره، ونعوذ بالله من شرور أنفسنا، ومن سيئات أعمالنا، من يهده الله فلا مضل له، ومن يضل فلا هادي له، وأشهد أن لا إله إلا الله وحده لا شريك له، وأشهد أن سيدنا محمداً عبده ورسوله، اللهم صلّ وسلم وبارك على سيدنا محمد وعلى آله وأصحابه ومن تبعه إلى يوم الدين

يَا أَيُّهَا الَّذِينَ آمَنُوا اتَّقُوا اللَّهَ حَقَّ تُقَاتِهِ وَلَا تَمُوتُنَّ إِلَّا وَأَنْتُمْ مُسْلِمُونَ [آل عمران:102]، أما بعد
فإن أصدق الحديث كتاب الله، وأحسن الهدي هدي محمد، وشر الأمور محدثاتها، وكل محدثة بدعة، وكل بدعة ضلالة، وكل ضلالة في النار

Today we continue our series on the character of the Prophet ﷺ. We study his character not simply to admire it, but to follow his example in our daily lives. Allah has commanded us to take him as our role model:

﴿لَقَدْ كَانَ لَكُمْ فِي رَسُولِ اللَّهِ أُسْوَةٌ حَسَنَةٌ﴾ [سورة الأحزاب، الآية 21]

“Indeed, in the Messenger of Allah you have an excellent example.” [Al-Ahzab, 33:21]

But we cannot follow an example we do not understand. That is why, in each khutbah, we examine one quality of his character and ask ourselves: How can I develop this quality in my own life?

In the previous two khutbahs, we discussed **truthfulness in speech and honoring commitments** even with enemies during war. Today, insha'Allah, we turn to another essential quality: **respect for others and the protection of their dignity**. This respect rests on two fundamental principles.

First: We must not judge people merely by suspicion or claim to know what is hidden in their hearts. We only judge by what is apparent and established, while leaving hidden intentions to Allah.

Second: We must protect people's privacy and honor, whether they are present or absent.

Both principles are brought together in one remarkable verse from Surah Al-Hujurat:

﴿يَا أَيُّهَا الَّذِينَ آمَنُوا اجْتَنِبُوا كَثِيرًا مِّنَ الظَّنِّ إِنَّ بَعْضَ الظَّنِّ إِثْمٌ وَلَا تَجَسَّسُوا وَلَا يَغْتَبَ بَعْضُكُم بَعْضًا ۚ أَيُحِبُّ أَحَدُكُمْ أَن يَأْكُلَ لَحْمَ أَخِيهِ مَيْتًا فَكَرِهْتُمُوهُ ۚ وَاتَّقُوا اللَّهَ ۚ إِنَّ اللَّهَ تَوَّابٌ رَّحِيمٌ﴾

“O you who believe, avoid much suspicion, for indeed some suspicion is sin. And do not spy, nor backbite one another. Would any of you like to eat the flesh of his dead brother? You would detest it. And be mindful of Allah. Indeed, Allah accepts repentance, Most Merciful.” [Surah Al-Hujurat 49:12]

Notice the sequence: suspicion begins in the heart, spying follows through our actions, and backbiting spreads the harm through our tongues. What begins as an unverified

thought can end by destroying another person's reputation. Let us examine how the Prophet ﷺ taught us to close these doors.

Example 1: “Did You Split Open His Heart?”

During a military encounter, Usamah ibn Zayd رضي الله عنهما confronted a fighter from the opposing side. When the man was about to be struck, he declared “La ilaha illa Allah.” **“There is no god but Allah.”** Usamah nevertheless killed him, believing that the man had spoken only to save his life.

When the Prophet ﷺ learned what had happened, he was deeply disturbed. He asked Usamah: Did he say ‘La ilaha illa Allah,’ and you killed him?

Usamah explained: “O Messenger of Allah, he said it only out of fear of the weapon.” The Prophet ﷺ responded:

﴿أَفَلَا شَفَقْتَ عَنْ قَلْبِهِ حَتَّى تَعْلَمَ أَقَالَهَا أَمْ لَا﴾

“Did you split open his heart so that you knew whether he said it sincerely or not?” Narrated by Muslim and Al-Bukhari.

The Prophet ﷺ repeated his rebuke so forcefully that Usamah deeply regretted what he had done.

Consider the lesson: Even Usamah’s closeness to the Prophet ﷺ did not excuse his action. The sanctity of human life could not be overridden by an assumption about someone’s hidden intentions.

The Prophet ﷺ was teaching a fundamental moral principle: We must never treat our interpretation of another person’s intentions as though it were an established fact. And this lesson extends far beyond the battlefield.

How often do we hear ourselves saying: “He only said that because...” “She is just pretending”. Never turn suspicion into fact. Respecting others requires intellectual humility: recognizing that we may understand someone’s actions without truly knowing what is in their heart.

2. Respect People's Privacy

The Qur’anic command: ﴿وَلَا تَجَسَّسُوا﴾ “Do not spy.” The Prophet ﷺ strongly warned against searching for people’s hidden faults. He said:

“Do not harm the Muslims, do not shame them, and do not search for their faults. For whoever searches for the faults of his Muslim brother, Allah will search for his fault; and whoever Allah searches for his fault, He will expose him even in the privacy of his home.” Reported by At-Tirmidhi and Dawud

The lesson is profound: Just because we can discover something about another person does not mean we have the right to discover it. Today’s Technology makes spying

easier: private messages, photographs, online activity, and old mistakes can all be exposed.

Investigating credible wrongdoing to protect others or establish justice may be necessary. Searching private lives to humiliate people is different. Islam demands justice without abandoning moral principles. The command remains: ﴿وَلَا تَجَسَّسُوا﴾ “Do not spy.”

3. Protect People's Honor — Even When They Are Absent

The qur’anic command (وَلَا يَغْتَابَ بَعْضُكُم بَعْضًا) **Do not backbite one another**. The Prophet ﷺ did not leave the meaning of backbiting open to interpretation. He defined it precisely. He asked his Companions:

« أَتَذَرُونَ مَا الْغَيْبَةُ؟ » قَالُوا: اللَّهُ وَرَسُولُهُ أَعْلَمُ. قَالَ: « ذِكْرُكَ أَخَاكَ بِمَا يَكْرَهُ ». قِيلَ: أَفَرَأَيْتَ إِنْ كَانَ فِي أَخِي مَا أَقُولُ؟ قَالَ: « إِنْ كَانَ فِيهِ مَا تَقُولُ فَقَدْ اغْتَابْتَهُ، وَإِنْ لَمْ يَكُنْ فِيهِ فَقَدْ بَهْتَهُ »

“Do you know what backbiting is?” They said: “Allah and His Messenger know best.” He said: **“It is mentioning about your brother something he dislikes.”** Someone asked: “What if what I say about my brother is true?” He ﷺ said: **“If what you say about him is true, you have backbitten him; and if it is not true, you have slandered him.”** [Narrated by Muslim]

Truthfulness does not automatically justify revealing another person's faults. Sometimes backbiting is even disguised as concern: “May Allah forgive our brother, but unfortunately, he has this weakness...” We may sound compassionate while unnecessarily damaging someone's reputation.

Of course, this prohibition does not prevent us from reporting wrongdoing, seeking necessary advice, warning someone of a genuine danger, or giving truthful testimony. But even then, we should say only what is necessary for that legitimate purpose.

The Prophet ﷺ also taught us that protecting someone's honor is not merely avoiding backbiting ourselves. It includes defending those who are absent. He said:

« مَنْ رَدَّ عَنْ عِرْضِ أَخِيهِ رَدَّ اللَّهُ عَنْ وَجْهِهِ النَّارَ يَوْمَ الْقِيَامَةِ »

“Whoever defends the honor of his brother, Allah will turn the Fire away from his face on the Day of Resurrection.” [Narrated by At-Tirmidhi]

When someone attacks an absent person, we can correct misinformation, change the subject, or refuse to participate. A person's dignity should not depend on being present to defend it.

So, before speaking about someone who is absent, let us ask three questions: 1. Is what I am saying true? 2. Is there a legitimate and necessary reason to say it? 3. Am I saying only what that reason requires, and nothing more?

Truthfulness is essential, but not every truth needs to be shared.

أقول قولي هذا واستغفر الله العظيم لي ولكم ولسائر المسلمين من كل ذنب فاستغفروه إنه هو الغفور الرحيم

الحمد لله وأشهد أن لا إله إلا الله وحده لا شريك له ، وأشهد أن سيدنا محمدًا عبده ورسوله ، صلى الله عليه وعلى آله وأصحابه ومن سار على نهجهم واهتدى بهديهم .أما بعد: .عباد الله: أوصيكم ونفسي بتقوى الله

Bring these lessons home. Ask yourself:

- Do I turn interpretations into facts?
- Do I seek the truth fairly, or assume the worst?
- Does someone's dignity leave when they leave the room?

Trustworthiness means protecting the dignity of people, not merely their possessions.

This week, make three commitments:

- First: Speak precisely. Separate knowledge from suspicion.
- Second: Defend the absent. Refuse needless attacks on other's reputations.
- Third: Repair harm. Seek forgiveness, correct unfair statements where possible.

Our character is measured not only by how we treat people face to face, but by how we speak of them in their absence.

Surah Al-Hujurat ends by opening the door to repentance: ﴿إِنَّ اللَّهَ تَوَّابٌ رَّحِيمٌ﴾ **“Indeed, Allah accepts repentance, Most Merciful.”** We can change today by repenting.

O Allah, purify our hearts from unjust suspicion, protect our tongues from backbiting, and guide us to respect the dignity of every human being.

اللهم صلّ وسلم وبارك على سيدنا محمد وعلى آله وأصحابه
اللهم اهدنا فيمن هديت ، وعافنا فيمن عافيت ، وتولنا فيمن توليت ، وبارك لنا فيما أعطيت ، وقنا واصرف عنا
شر ما قضيت ، فإنك تقضي بالحق ، ولا يقضى عليك ،
لهم وأدخلنا برحمتك في عبادك الصالحين ، أخرجنا من ظلمات الجهل والوهم إلى أنوار العلم
اللهم اجعلنا ممن يستمعون القول فيتبعون أحسنه
اللهم بفضلك ورحمتك أعل كلمة الحق والدين ، وانصر الإسلام ، وأعز المسلمين يا أكرم الأكرمين .

O Allah, spread your mercy upon us, shower us with Your blessings, increase our knowledge, grant us forgiveness, and reward us by the company of Your prophets in the highest place in Heaven, Al-Ferdous Al-Aala.

O Allah, forgive our parents and all our friends and relatives who have passed away and make their graves a garden from heaven and grant them the Ferdous Al-Ala.

O Allah, heal our sick and grant them full and speedy recovery.

O Allah, guide our children, protect them and make them righteous.

O Allah grant victory to our brothers and sisters suffering injustice and oppression heal their trauma, protect their helpless, fulfill their needs and grant them peace and prosperity.

O Allah, we ask you in this blessed hour with every name you have elected for yourself that none of us leave this gathering, but his pains have been relieved, his worries have been removed, his debts have been paid, his weaknesses have been concealed, his sins have been forgiven, and his needs have been fulfilled,

إِنَّ اللَّهَ وَمَلَائِكَتَهُ يُصَلُّونَ عَلَى النَّبِيِّ يَا أَيُّهَا الَّذِينَ آمَنُوا صَلُّوا عَلَيْهِ وَسَلِّمُوا تَسْلِيمًا (الأحزاب 33:56)
اللهم صلّ وسلم وبارك على سيدنا محمد وعلى آله وأصحابه وَأَقِمِ الصَّلَاةَ إِنَّ الصَّلَاةَ تَنْهَى عَنِ الْفَحْشَاءِ وَالْمُنْكَرِ